

THE OTHER BRITISH INVASION: THEORIZING BRITISH PARLIAMENTARY DEBATE

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British Parliamentary (BP) debate or Worlds is a competitive debate format whose roots have a long fascinating history. A. Craig Baird (1923) was the first to report on the format to the nascent American professional debating community in the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*, most notably pointing out that British debate had no judges and no decision. For Baird, BP was a novel form of public debate—less interested in finding a winner or loser and more interested in the demonstration of argumentative skill. BP's current iteration is now a more familiar competitive activity: teams of two prepare a case for or against a motion in 15 minutes. Once preparation time expires, four teams divided between a government and opposing benches (opening government (OG), closing government (CG), opening opposition (OO), and closing opposition(CO)) take turns giving 7-minute speeches advocating or opposing the motion. Then a panel of judges ranks the teams 1st through 4th, giving the best team the 1. In contrast to other formats, where each judge's vote counts independently, BP favors consensus—the judges must agree on the ranking. The international championship tournament for this event is called the World Universities Debating Championship (WUDC). The WUDC and contemporary BP are so closely wed together that they are often used

interchangeably. In much the same way that people may use the National Debate Tournament (NDT) and policy debate as synonyms.

BP debate is one of the fastest growing debate formats in the U.S. (Eckstein & Bartanen, 2015). While BP has enjoyed a robust East Coast circuit since the 1970s thanks to the American Parliamentary Debate Association (APDA), few domestic tournaments existed elsewhere. In the past ten years, however, BP migrated from the East Coast toward the West Coast, and then back to the East Coast from the west through programs that were more familiar with National Parliamentary Debate Association (NPDA) or Cross Examination Debate Association (CEDA) debate. Now, there are a variety of tournaments across the country that feature BP debate. 2005 marked the first United States Universities Debating Championship (USU) at Claremont College in California, which attracted approximately 50 teams. Since then, participation tripled: the 2015 USU held at the University of Alaska brought more than 150 teams to Anchorage.

BP is not a seamless import to the United States. Its own rich history and cultural contexts clash at times with the traditional and familiar competitive debate practices of US debate practitioners. Perhaps most significant is the fact that the majority of BP debate programs worldwide are student run, most without any contact or participation by faculty whatsoever. BP's recent widespread US adoption, however, most often occurred under the direction of a faculty member who serves as the debate coach. Many programs that featured other debating formats saw BP as a way to better realize institutional goals.

Several other formats, like policy debate, have enjoyed the benefits of an institutionalized advocate,

such as a faculty debate coach, for many years. For BP this represents a significant development because it offers an additional safeguard to protect a program. For student run programs, budgets are often subject to the whims of a constantly changing student government. If the debating program is lucky enough to secure a university budget line, they are perpetually on the chopping block. The figure of a faculty coach legitimizes intercollegiate debate as more deeply ingrained in the academic program, which can help protect programs by making them co-curricular rather than extra-curricular and thus more closely related to a college or university's academic mission.

Such benefits of curricular integration come with a cost: the coaches must reconcile their tripartite obligations of teaching, coaching, and researching. Successfully balancing these different obligations entails connecting them: teaching, coaching, and researching should not only draw from the same well, but reflect upon the possible connections they create between one another. Thus, we reimagine the debate coach as the peripatetic scholar, a term that not only invokes the great influence Aristotle has over argumentation and rhetoric as a *praxis*, but also the ancient sense of a wandering teacher. Although debate coaches do most of their pedagogy on the road, or with a sense of movement (between tournaments in vans, during short lunches at competitions, etc.) we wish to put most of our focus on the idea that the debate peripatetic moves between sites of knowing, sites of scholarship, and sites of performance. The sites of knowing range from the spoken word to the academic article, the voices of a community in a web forum and the monograph of the critical journalist. We see the peripatetic as the scholar equally comfortable deriving useful information from international news sources online as well as dusty

bound journals in dark library stacks.

The peripatetic scholar's expertise should inform her coaching. If she has a background in rhetoric, argumentation, philosophy, or a number of other disciplines, then she can operationalize this into the normal tasks surrounding preparation for competition. For example, a background in rhetorical studies offers a peripatetic scholar expertise to guide position development, give tips for judge adaption, and assess argumentative strategy. Since the audience for a BP competition is the reasonable person, such expertise has both a perceived immediate value to the competitive debater, and a long-term pedagogical benefit to the student.

The peripatetic scholar must also stay abreast of the field, less so the trends of the tournament world. We suggest re-invigoration of forensic scholarship as the preferred way for this to happen. Debate has been an object of scholarly inquiry since the dawn of speech communication as a discipline. Specifically and more recently, policy debate has been problematized as citizenship training, laboratory of experimentation and a site of political agency (Mitchell, 1998, 2010; Panetta, 1990). Debate-as-object scholarship does more than refine debating practices. It offers new places to stand in order to take in the fields of rhetoric and argumentation, offering new vantage points for the consideration of long-held positions on theory and practice. This creates a recursive loop for peripatetic scholar, codifying their perspectives in scholarship, which can further inform coaching and teaching practice. In turn, the teaching and practice, offer new resources for scholarship.

It is in this vein that we offer the following special issue on theorizing BP. We think theorizing

BP can produce interventions in the art of coaching and relevant conversations in the discipline that stoke the formation of the position of peripatetic scholar. We think that BP debate offers a number of interesting wrinkles around deliberative rhetoric, judicial reasoning, argument evaluation, extremism, and praxis. These wrinkles, we hope, further the conversation about the role of faculty who are involved in competitive debating, as well as the student who chooses debate as a significant portion of her undergraduate journey. Some of the topics covered in this issue include theorizing propositions, cooperation, deliberation, mimetics, and deliberation. Each contributor explores how BP creates novel opportunities for a democratic pedia that extends beyond the tournament space. Taken as a whole, this issue supplies peripatetic scholars a wealth of normative models and insights to further guide coaching. And hopefully, it will provoke broader conversations at the intersection of competitive intercollegiate debate and theorizing.

The rising interest in and growth of BP debate programs across the United States gives us motive for this special issue, but can also be a source of tension for those familiar with the history of various debating formats in the United States. We offer this issue in hopes of turning the conversation about BP toward what BP is instead of what BP is *not*. We believe theorizing BP gives it a set of its own terms, terms which can avoid it becoming a “protest format” - a format where the primary articulation of its value is through the competitive norms it willfully excludes. Such a temptation is made easier when many peripatetic scholars are more familiar with other competitive debating cultures in the United States, and reach for such attributions as a matter of rhetorical efficacy to describe their decision to become involved

in BP debating. BP is much richer than a selection of “None of the Above,” but requires more theorizing about its own positive contributions to prove this. BP debate is much more than its absence of peculiarities of practice within American formats. This journal issue hopes to prove that and encourage further development of independent justification for BP format from a variety of fields of study.

The goal of this special issue of *Contemporary Argumentation & Debate* offers the nascent idea of the BP peripatetic scholar open for inquiry, a site to think about BP and theorize its significance. In short, we hope this special issue offers a prelude to begin a broader conversation about BP debate. We hope some of our questions, interventions, and insights reverberate across the broader college debate community.

We hope these pieces that follow in this special issue stoke the conversation not only about the value of BP on its own terms, but offer new terms for the discussion of debate programs in the United States as a whole. What are the terms under which we teach and practice debating? What do we hope to get from it? And what is it that debate asks of us? We believe that the power of theorizing debate is not a boxing, a limiting, or a drawing of borders but a liberatory move designed to encourage movement and discussion (as opposed to mere description). We believe theorizing to be an intellectual passport that liberates the peripatetic to circulate between ideas and practices, informing the incredibly important normative discussion about the purpose of collegiate debating in which we should always already be engaged.

References

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